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BRIEF CASES

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JOHN QUELCH

ALISA ZALOSH

Crescent Pure

Sarah Ryan, vice president of marketing for Portland Drake Beverages (PDB), a manufacturer of organic juices and sparkling waters, glanced at her smartphone as a text message buzzed into view. It was her husband, wanting to know if she would be home for dinner. "Working late again, home @ 10," she quickly replied. It was Monday, August 12, 2013, and Ryan could not remember the last time she and her husband had enjoyed a leisurely meal together. She had just a few weeks to finalize a product-positioning strategy for a recent product acquisition, Crescent Pure (Crescent). Crescent was a non-alcoholic functional beverage[1] with an impending launch in three U.S. markets. PDB acquired Crescent in July 2013; the drink's combination of energy-enhancing, hydrating, and all-organic ingredients made it a natural extension for PDB's existing organic product lines. However, PDB's management team disagreed about which of two viable positioning strategies would maximize Crescent's revenues. Some felt the drink's energizing ingredients supported an energy-drink positioning, while others felt that due to the drink's hydrating elements, a sports-drink positioning made more sense.

PDB executives knew that some of the country's largest national beverage companies planned to launch all-natural versions of their own sports and energy drinks in the second half of 2015, and wanted to beat them to market. However, production capacity constraints prevented PDB from launching the drink nationally until early 2015. As a result, PDB planned to embark on a "soft launch" of Crescent in three western states (California, Oregon, and Washington) in January 2014. PDB projected that these three states represented 15% of national functional beverage demand.

Michael Booth, PDB's CEO, had tasked Ryan with evaluating the positioning opportunities for Crescent and asked her to recommend a positioning strategy to the executive team. He gave her six weeks to work on the strategy: PDB was under pressure to define the product by October 1 in order

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HBS Professor John Quelch and writer Alisa Zalosh prepared this case solely as a basis for class discussion and not as an endorsement, a source of primary data, or an illustration of effective or ineffective management. Although based on real events, and despite occasional references to actual companies, this case is fictitious and any resemblance to actual persons or entities is coincidental.

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to negotiate with beverage distributors and retailers, and to hire advertisers to develop ad campaigns in time for the January 2014 launch. PDB planned to spend $750,000 on advertising for Crescent in 2014 and used that figure as a benchmark earnings goal. If 2014 profits met or exceeded the goal, PDB would fund Crescent's national expansion in 2015.

Ryan knew that Booth wanted to hear (1) industry specifics related to each of the two positioning options, (2) the potential benefits and drawbacks of each option, and (3) her final recommendation. However, as Ryan delved deeper into the research provided by PDB's director of market research—the results of which now occupied a sizeable file on her computer, she began to wonder if a third positioning option focusing on the drink's healthy and organic roots would attract the most consumers.

Ryan would present her findings to Booth and the management team on Monday, September 16.

U.S. beverage industry: Non-alcoholic

In 2013, the non-alcoholic beverage market—which included water, dairy, juice, soda, and functional beverages—was estimated to be $131 billion and was projected to grow to $164 billion by 2018.[2] This market had suffered due to restrained consumer spending during the economic recession, but the trend was slowly reversing as the economy recovered. Many new products were launched in the segment by 2012. This wave of introductions was expected to continue into the foreseeable future.

Beverage distribution in the U.S.

Distributing food and beverage products, which involved moving products from a manufacturing site into the hands of consumers, entailed many steps and varied by the size and influence of both retailers and manufacturers. In 2013, the largest U.S. retailers, known as "big box" retailers, often had their own product distribution systems in place to handle purchasing, transportation, and stocking.

For most medium- and smaller-size food and beverage manufacturers, distribution was not straightforward. Manufacturers typically retained distributors to facilitate the process of getting their products onto retail shelves.[3] Distributors maintained relationships with retailers and sold them products from expansive catalogs. Once a retailer agreed to sell an individual product, the distributor transported and delivered the manufacturer's product from the manufacturing facility or storage warehouse to the retailer. Sometimes distributor responsibility included shelving and displaying products. Distributors assigned an average margin of 25% to the goods they purchased from the manufacturer; the more of a product they sold, the more revenue they generated. They continually refined their catalogue to include products they believed would generate the highest demand.

Specialization was common among brokers and distributors, and they often forged relationships with retailers and manufacturers within a niche segment. Some distributors focused on organic products. Others developed expertise in ethnic or gourmet offerings. When selling to consumers, retailers added an average margin of 40% to products purchased from distributors.

Crescent Pure: Company history

Peter Hooper, a native of Crescent, Oregon, saw a market opportunity for a healthy, energizing drink. He founded Crescent in 2008. Organic, all-natural food and beverages became ubiquitous in the Pacific Northwest region in the 1990s and early 2000s, and Hooper found popular energy and performance-enhancing drinks unhealthy, too sweet, and artificial. He began experimenting with different ingredients in order to craft an organic, all-natural beverage lightly infused with organic

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juices, herbal stimulants, and electrolytes. He wanted a drink that would refresh, energize, and enhance mental focus. What began as a hobby became a business as Hooper saw growing local demand for his product.

Crescent's herbal stimulants (guarana seed and ginseng) delivered 80 milligrams of caffeine, roughly the same amount of "energy effect" as a cup of coffee. This amounted to half the energy contained in a similar serving of the two leading energy beverages on the market, Fright and Razor. Furthermore, Crescent's sugar quotient (derived from organic, raw cane sugar) was 70% less than leading energy and sports drinks, on average.

Twelve months after launching his small business, Hooper secured legal protection for his proprietary recipe. He manufactured and distributed the drink from a rented Portland, Oregon, warehouse, in small batches to regional outlets. Crescent benefited from launching in a region that embraced the "locavore" movement.[4] A high percentage of Oregonians supported healthy, organic food choices and the local businesses that made them available. After Hooper promoted his drinks at farmers' markets and local food shows and pursuing local retailers in Oregon, demand grew in the Portland area for Crescent. Distribution eventually included two hundred retail outlets (including regional grocery chains and small, independently owned grocers and cafes), and the company was selling 1,000 cases per month.[5] The drink retailed for $3.75 for an 8-ounce can.

Crescent acquisition by PDB Beverages

In late 2012, Michael Booth, CEO of PDB Beverages, noticed his adult sons drinking Crescent. They had discovered the drink through word of mouth. Booth's sons found the drink refreshing, energizing, and healthier than other mainstream beverage alternatives. At work, they found Crescent helped them remain productive without the crash that occurred after they drank soda or other high-fructose beverages.

With consumer demand for organic food and beverage products rising, PDB's revenues had increased to $120.5 million by 2012. Booth felt it important to expand PDB's trusted and popular suite of organic products; he knew that functional beverages—specifically energy and low-calorie sports drinks—were rapidly growing segments, and sought to expand into these areas through acquisitions. He thought that early entrants would be in a good position to steal market share from market leaders in 2015. PDB thought it could leverage its manufacturing facility, organic suppliers, and distributor relationships to expand Crescent's presence in states geographically adjacent to Oregon in 2014, and then nationally in 2015. After months of research and negotiations, PDB acquired Crescent.

Short-term production capacity restraints limited PDB's production of Crescent to 12,000 cases per month in 2014. PDB management decided that Crescent's retail price would be $2.75, or 27% below the drink's original selling price. PDB wanted Crescent to reflect PDB's pricing strategy in other product lines, which was to deliver quality organic products at affordable prices. PDB had experimented with premium pricing in previous product launches, and the strategy had backfired. In addition, PDB volume—rather than markups—drove the company's juice and sparkling water product sales, and the management team felt that Crescent's sales strategy should be no different. The company's favorable supplier terms made the drop in price affordable. Variable costs for Crescent were $1.02 per can; PDB's wholesale price to distributors was $29.76 per case (or $1.24 per can).[6]

PDB wanted to negotiate with distributors for the 2014 West Coast launch. Because of limited production capacity, and to ensure distributor profitability if inventory sold out, PDB used only three distributors. Booth calculated that distributors' monthly costs would average $34,000 during

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Crescent's first year (including the cost of goods, marketing materials, employee training, and compensation). Before selecting and negotiating with distributors, however, PDB needed to determine the most effective positioning for Crescent. The drink's positioning would influence where the product was sold and, therefore, which distributors PDB would select.

Crescent: Ingredients and packaging

Packaged in a sleek, tall silver 8-ounce can with a simple crescent logo and lime green and orange accents, Crescent was a clear-colored liquid. Its taste included a hint of fruit and was less sweet than most fruit juice, cola, sports drinks, and energy drinks. Each can contained one 80-calorie serving. For flavor, Crescent contained lime juice, lemon juice, and small amounts of raw cane sugar and green tea. Energy stimulants included guarana, a plant native to South America whose seeds contained roughly double the concentration of caffeine found in coffee beans, and ginseng, an herbal supplement known to relieve fatigue and boost concentration and endurance. A dash of fine-grain salt delivered electrolytes with each serving.

All Crescent ingredients were "certified organic," which meant that during farming, harvesting, and production, no chemicals were used or applied to alter or enhance the ingredients' natural state; the drink's label highlighted its certified-organic roots. In addition to the nutritional information included on each can, the drink also listed its energy content (80 milligrams of caffeine per serving).

Crescent product positioning: Options

Ryan agreed that Crescent's product attributes could support positioning in one of two functional beverage categories: energy drinks or sports drinks. However, she needed in-depth research on market sizes, competitors, and consumer preferences, in order to craft a comprehensive positioning strategy. Ryan knew that good positioning, if successful, could shape potential customers' opinions about a product or service before they'd even seen or experienced the product in question.

Ryan asked Matt Levor, PDB's director of market research, for help. After calling to explain her needs and timing, she emailed him to summarize her thoughts on potential approaches.

July 20, 2013

Hi Matt,

Thanks for helping me with my research requests on such short notice. Your insight into consumer demographics, perceptions, consumption habits, and the competitive landscape for both energy and sports drinks, is appreciated. My high-level thoughts on approaches are below:

Energy Drinks: Crescent delivers a boost of energy to combat fatigue and promote mental focus. Positioning Crescent as an energy-enhancing beverage would reinforce existing perceptions from Oregon, where an informal consumer survey conducted at an outdoor music festival indicated consumers viewed "energy" as Crescent's most descriptive characteristic. Prices for energy drinks in the U.S. range from $2 to $5 per can, based on can size (8 oz., 12 oz., or 16 oz.) and retail outlet. The average price for 8 oz. of energy drink is $2.99, above our $2.75 price point.

Thirty-four percent of the population said they consumed an energy beverage in the last six months; the projected market for energy drinks in 2013 is $8.5 billion.[7] Most advertising for energy drinks targets the most enthusiastic consumers, men 18 to 24

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years old. Visually startling images—think extreme sports participants—paired with loud rock music (when audio is available), reinforce a message that implies "Our drinks help you do everything you want to do (even risky things!)."

I think Crescent's organic certification and minimal (as compared to leading competitors) caffeine content provide strong differentiators for the energy market. Our drink is a healthier alternative to leading brands, whose artificial sweeteners and excessive levels of stimulants are likely to prompt a subset of consumers to switch to healthier options.

I'm concerned about the long-term viability of this market. I've read that regular consumption of these drinks has fallen because of negative media attention. If you could find out more about current and projected consumption patterns, as well as the impact of negative media attention, I'd greatly appreciate it. I look forward to reading your research on these issues next week.

Sports Drinks: In 2012, the market for sports drinks was $6.3 billion; 42% of sports beverage drinkers considered sports drinks "anytime beverages"[8] and did not associate them only with exercise. They attracted a wider consumer base than did energy drinks, and regular users consumed them more often. Sports drinks come in a variety of sizes and average $1.00 to $2.00 for 12-oz. and 24-oz. containers, respectively. Generally, ingredients include water, sugar, and salt.

Crescent's hydrating elements, paired with the mental focus and energy boost, can enhance athletic performance. It can also stave off post-workout fatigue if consumed after exercise. (Fright and Razor, the market leaders, are touted as performance enhancing by "extreme sports" professionals.) Perhaps Crescent's low sugar content and all-natural ingredients can appeal to health-conscious consumers seeking healthier "anytime" beverages that are free from artificial ingredients and sweeteners. Crescent's $2.75 price point for an 8-oz. can will be significantly higher than are those of similarly sized sports drinks, so our positioning and advertising will have to build the case for its premium price.

Again, thanks for your help. I look forward to following up with you next week.

Sarah

Market Research

Levor had limited time in which to do research and therefore relied heavily on third-party sources. Drawing from a "state-of-the-industry" study published by a beverage industry trade association, three consumer surveys conducted by a private research firm, several academic reports, and industry media coverage, Levor provided Ryan with most of the market information she requested.

Energy drinks: Market and consumer data, competition, threats, and opportunities

- **Market size:** The market for energy drinks[9] was growing; between 2010 and 2012, the market for energy drinks had grown by 40%. It was estimated to be $8.5 billion in the United States in 2013; forecasts projected that figure to reach $13.5 billion by 2018.[10]

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- **Consumer data:** The largest group of energy-drink consumers were males between ages 18 and 34.[11] Parents of children were also more likely to consume energy drinks.[12] The highest volume of energy drinks consumed was by respondents with a household income below $25,000 per year.[13]

- **Competition:** Together, Fright, Razor, Torque, and Stellar accounted for 85% of category revenue (34%, 27%, 16%, and 8%, respectively). The remaining 15% was split between roughly thirty independent regional and national producers.

- **Opportunity:** Sales of energy drinks with lower levels of caffeine and purer ingredients were rising due to consumer demand for healthier food and beverage choices.

- **Threats:** News stories were highlighting the drinks' alleged health risks: 32% of consumers over 18 indicated they drank an energy drink in the last six months, 11% of whom were drinking fewer energy drinks than they had a year earlier, due to concerns about health and safety.[14]

Sports drinks: Market and consumer data, competition, threats, and opportunities

The market increased only 9% between 2007 and 2012. In 2012, the market for sports drinks reached $6.3 billion in the United States and was expected to grow to $9.58 billion by 2017.[15]

- **Consumer data:** Roughly half of men drank sports drinks, while only a third of women did. Although 40% of men found sports drinks refreshing, only 27% of females did.[16] Sports drinks appealed to younger consumers—62% of those between ages 18 and 24, and 77% of those ages 12 to 17.

- **Competition:** Gleam and Drip had 73% and 21% market share, respectively. The remaining 6% of market share ($378 million) was split fairly evenly among roughly 20 producers.

- **Threats:** Concern regarding rising childhood obesity rates resulted in government-mandated guidelines to remove high-calorie sugary drinks and snacks, including sports drinks, from school vending machines beginning in 2014.

- **Opportunity:** New diet and low-sugar sports drinks were growth areas for the industry. Diet and low-sugar sports beverages, which did not exist before 2009, had grown by 33% between 2010 and 2012, taking market share from traditional sports drinks.[17] The market size for diet and low-sugar sports drinks was expected to increase from $1.4 billion in 2012 to $2.97 billion in 2017.

Sports drinks and energy drinks: consumer studies

Levor uncovered a consumer study that examined how consumers perceived energy drinks and sports drinks. See **Table 1** for percentages of respondents who felt a specific word was reflective of energy and sports drinks in 2013.[18] (Respondents could assign multiple descriptors to each category.)

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Table 1 Percentage of respondents who indicated a word that described energy or sports drinks

	Energy Drinks	Sports Drinks
Refreshing	12%	34%
Healthy	6%	16%
Affordable	5%	11%
Functional	22%	28%
Too sweet	9%	8%
Suitable for Teens	7%	22%
Fun	9%	11%
Natural	4%	6%
Hydrating	11%	49%
None of these	52%	27%

Levor also provided Ryan with a series of perceptual maps that measured consumer perception of leading sports drinks and energy drinks on two sets of paired factors: (1) energy and hydration, and (2) nutrition and taste. See **Exhibit 1** and **Exhibit 2** for these perceptual maps.

Crescent: Consumer study

Ryan pressed Levor for a way to understand how Crescent consumers would respond to **Table 1**'s descriptors. In 2010, Hooper had set up an online store, anticipating a future focus on online sales. The online store had processed under 1,000 orders in aggregate, but Levor thought that this self-selected group of customers could provide valuable demographic and psychographic intelligence.

Levor emailed all Crescent online customers a link to an online survey that asked basic demographic information, then provided the descriptions cited in **Table 1**'s consumer survey. Respondents who completed the survey within four days would receive a free case of Crescent shipped to their door. More than one-third of respondents completed the survey. See **Table 2** and **Table 3** for survey results.

Table 2 Demographics of Crescent online consumers

Age ranges	
18–24	44%
25–34	36%
35–44	15%
45–54	3%
55+	2%
Male	59%
Female	41%
College degree	62%
Household income (median)	$42,500

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Table 3 Percentage of respondents who described Crescent

Descriptor	
Refreshing	35%
Healthy	22%
Affordable	29%
Functional	47%
Too sweet	9%
Suitable for teens	8%
Fun	19%
Natural	38%
Hydrating	29%

Note: Respondents could assign multiple descriptors.

Retailer feedback

Levor contacted ten large Portland-area retailers that carried Crescent. Retailers indicated that their inventory of Crescent depleted quickly; some had increased the price by 25%, and still sold out before inventory was replenished. Crescent appeared to be most popular among consumers aged 18 to 30, and retailers indicated that a higher percentage of women purchased Crescent than they expected. Younger men often purchased six or more cans at a time.

Focus group feedback

In early August, Levor conducted three focus group sessions for Crescent. Three customer segments participated: women aged 25–33; men aged 18–24; and men aged 25–35. Each session included eight participants, none of whom had heard of, or tasted, Crescent. He summarized the results in an email to Ryan:

August 9, 2013

Hi Sarah,

I know you are under pressure to finalize Crescent's positioning next month, so I figured I would email you my informal thoughts in advance of my formal presentation, which you'll have in three weeks due to vacation and planned travel. I've highlighted four key findings:

1. ***Taste:*** *It appears Crescent's taste appeals to most consumers. While some participants were notably more pleased with the taste, there were no unfavorable reactions.*

2. ***Energy content:*** *About half the participants were initially concerned about the energy component. Once they learned the energy content was equal to the caffeine found in a cup of coffee, only 25% remained concerned. Older consumers said that they liked that Crescent was a healthy alternative to high-calorie, sugary energy drinks. Some younger consumers noted that Crescent had less energy than they had hoped.*

3. ***Customer profile:*** *Several consumers said that Crescent was exactly what they wanted in a beverage: healthy ingredients, good taste, and a slight pick-me-up. This interest appeared to reflect a focus on health and wellness, and transcended a specific age or demographic profile.*

4. ***Price:*** *Most participants knew the prices of competitive options and figured that due to Crescent's organic and energy ingredients, the price would be above $3.00. Most were happily surprised, but some questioned PDB's ability to deliver quality organic ingredients at $2.75.*

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Contemplating a broader positioning strategy: Organic beverage?

Ryan determined that younger, health-conscious consumers who regularly consumed energy or sports beverages were prospects for Crescent. Yet, she thought, was there a second market of potential Crescent consumers, one comprising health-conscious consumers who consistently purchased organic and all-natural products? This segment avoided traditional energy and sports drinks because of their ingredients and perhaps because of psychographic positioning that did not resonate with their beliefs.

Ryan wondered if a third, "broad appeal" option would make the most sense for Crescent. What if Crescent positioned itself as an organic refreshment and capitalized on the growth of the organic food and beverage industry. In 2013, the "organic beverages" category included carbonated soft drinks, coffee, tea, fruit juice, energy drinks, milk, and soy beverages. Organic beverages claimed a price premium (on average 25%) over conventional beverages of the same variety.

Could PDB exploit Crescent's broad appeal with positioning that focused on health, wellness, and natural ingredients? This appeal implied that different segments valued different attributes: refreshing taste, mild energy boost, hydration, and organic ingredients. By limiting its positioning to just one or two of these attributes, PDB might risk excluding additional, lucrative customer segments.

Preparing for the meeting with Booth

Booth had wanted Ryan to recommend an approach so that he could identify possible distributors and retail outlets and hire advertising firms to develop and execute a strategy for the coming year. A broader approach would complicate these efforts. She knew timing was critical and that Booth wanted her to deliver an actionable recommendation. A broad approach would lengthen the product launch process—there would be more distributors and retailers to evaluate, to start. Was a media campaign that appealed to a wide range of consumers even feasible on a $750,000 ad budget? Such a campaign would take longer to develop and execute than would a more narrowly targeted campaign.

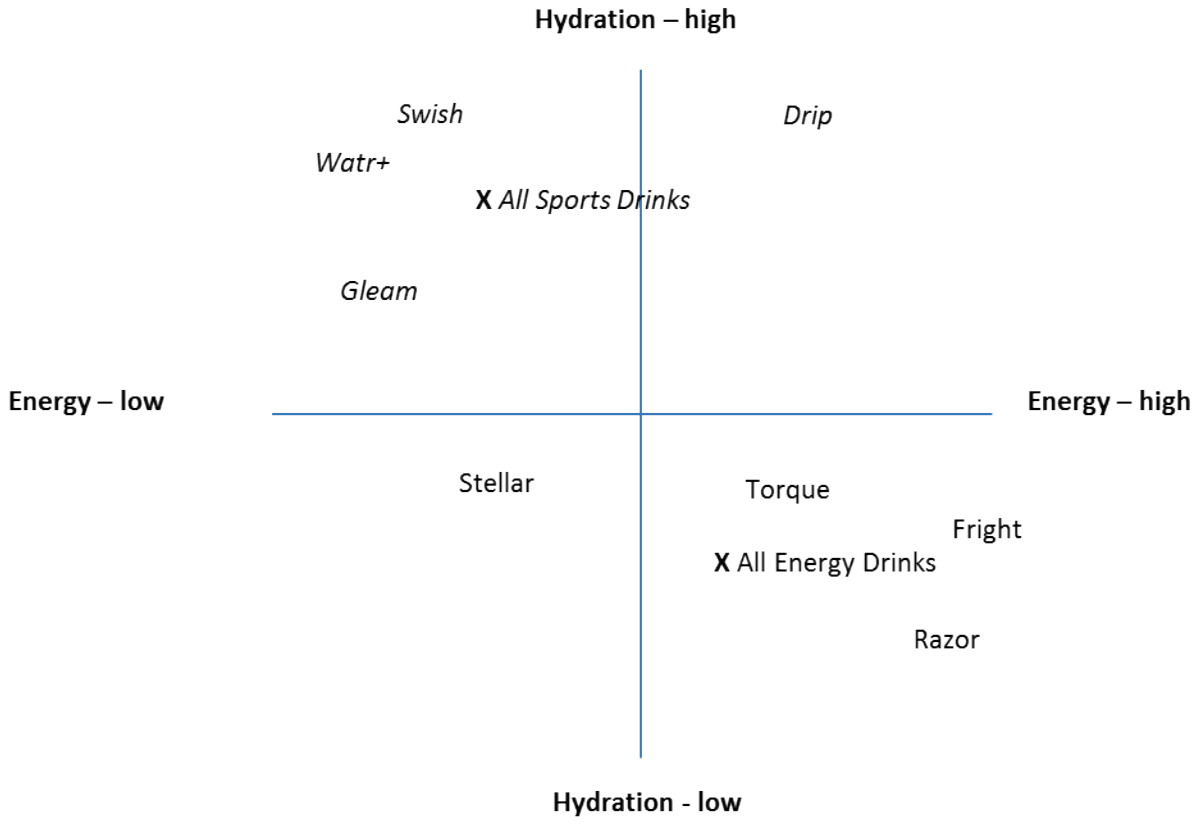
Ryan was due for a promotion in six months. Failing to reach the sales benchmark would not reflect well on her. If she argued for a broad positioning launch, however, and that strategy fulfilled or exceeded expectations, her initiative would elevate her standing in the company.

Ryan closed her laptop and left work. Tomorrow, she would review the research and begin to build her breakeven projections, estimating required sales for PDB to breakeven on 2014 advertising expenditures. As she exited the parking lot, she wondered if her husband had saved her some dinner.

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Exhibit 1 Perceptual Map: Hydration vs. Energy

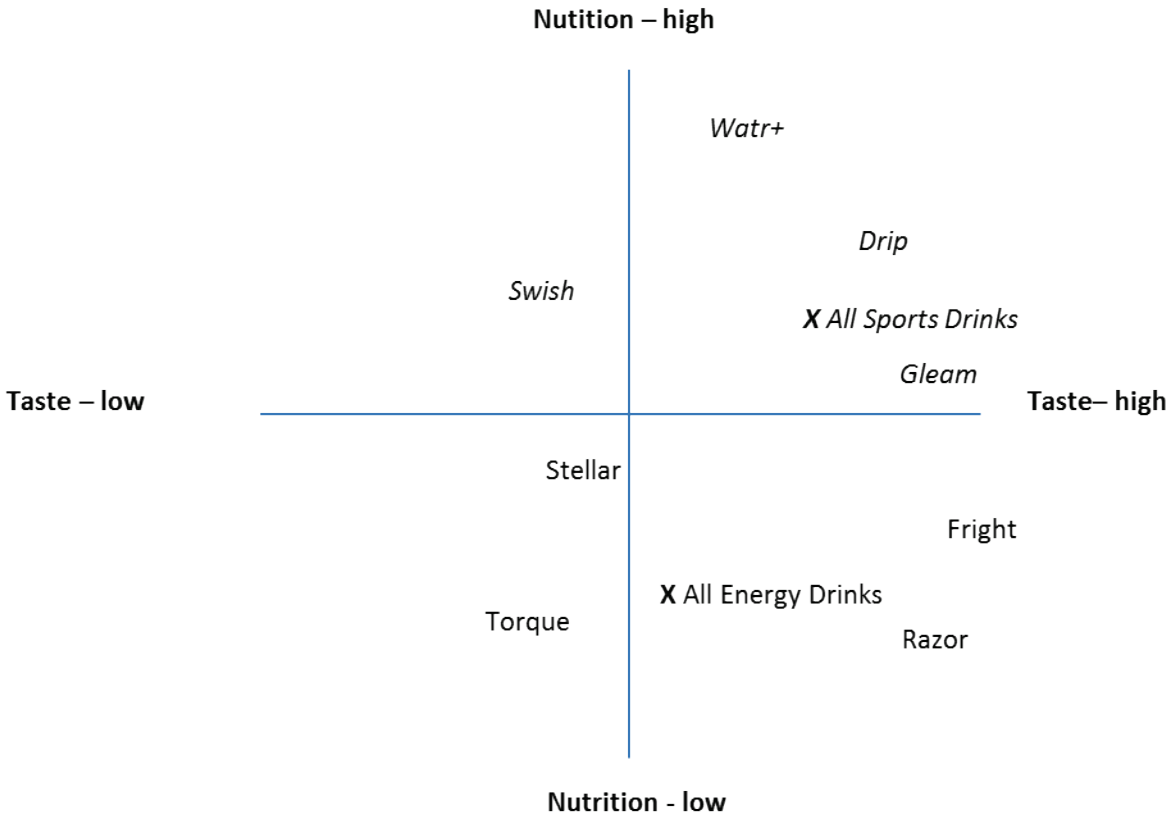


Note: Sports drinks are italicized; energy drinks are not.

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Exhibit 2 Perceptual Map: Nutrition vs. Taste



Note: Sports drinks are italicized; energy drinks are not.

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Endnotes

[1] Functional beverages delivered a specific benefit to consumers, usually health or performance related. For example, drinks designed to increase alertness, hydration, and immunity, as well as those designed to induce weight loss, were considered functional beverages.

[2] Source: Non-alcoholic Beverages U.S. Report, January 2014, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[3] Some manufacturers instead hired food and beverage brokers, or a combination of brokers and distributors, to sell their products.

[4] The "locavore" movement supports the sale of "local" food that is grown within a hundred miles of its point of purchase or consumption. Reduced travel time presumably enables the growth of crops without chemical preservatives and minimizes the amount of fossil fuel (gasoline) released into the environment as a result of transport.

[5] Each case contained twenty-four 8-ounce cans.

[6] Supplier costs would be further reduced with higher levels of production.

[7] Source: Non-alcoholic beverages, January 2014, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[8] Mintel Report: Sports Drinks 2012.

[9] Energy drink data do not include energy shots or energy powders, which can be added to water or juice.

[10] Source: Energy Drinks in U.S. 2013, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[11] Source: Energy Drinks in U.S. 2013, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[12] Source: Energy Drinks in U.S. 2013, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[13] Energy Drinks in U.S. 2013, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[14] Energy Drinks in U.S. 2013, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[15] Sports Drinks U.S., September, 2012, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[16] Non-Alcoholic Beverages, January 2014, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[17] Sports Drinks U.S., September, 2012, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

[18] Data extrapolated from Non-alcoholic beverages, January 2014, Mintel, accessed April 2014.

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